his coal-carrying project while ceding ground on the campus location. Economic logic, after all, has to pass the people test. Especially when there are other leaders who can stir the vindaloo pot.

Michael Lobo, with his dramatic rags-to-riches story, is one of them. At Candolim in the Calangute constituency, he is going door-to-door with folded hands. Lobo used to be a dishwasher at a restaurant as a teenager but is now the owner of two resorts, two restaurants and a dozen bungalows. Known for his political manoeuvring skills, his return to the Congress—after nearly 17 years in the BJP—has helped galvanise the party. "The BJP has drifted away from the principles of Manohar Parrikar," he says, rationalising his move—and also his choice of the Congress as an "inclusive party" that does not "differentiate between people based on their caste and religion".

Lobo's arrival marks the mood of resurgence in the Grand Old Party, which hasn't had much to celebrate for five years. As a returnee, Lobo may be a curious fit in the party's present stand against turncoats, but it's holding fast to that, at least in the recent cases. (As Curtorim MLA Alexio Reginald Lourenco found to his dismay, being refused renomination as punishment for his week-long detour to the TMC in December!) It's a hard stand to take for a party that came down from 17 in 2017 to two in 2021, but it's a bold and widely appreciated decision nevertheless. And, riding on strong anti-incumbency sentiments, the Congress is making a virtue out of it by fielding many new faces.

Its confidence has spilled over to the tricky territory of alliance-making: it chose to tame Goa Forward Party (GFP) chief Vijai Sardesai's ambitions, offering only three seats against a demand of 12. But nothing reflected its new verve better than the way it refused to entertain the TMC's quest for a grand alliance against the BJP. The war of words between Congress poll in-charge P. Chidambaram and his TMC counterpart Mahua Moitra left both parties wounded. But the former never wavered. His question was simple: why would the Congress tie up with a party that was, till the other day, poaching from it? The TMC's counter is that it was at least stopping Congressmen from joining the BJP! "Opposition can't be singular. It has to be plural," argues Omprakash Mishra, TMC media head. "When we came to Goa, the Congress was in bad shape. Had they been in a position to defeat the BJP, we would not have come to Goa."

That arrival had indeed started with a blitz of 'friendly fire', back in October. First up, it lassoed in none other than then state Congress chief Luizinho Faleiro, followed by a whole series of candidates, from the Congress and elsewhere. But after its initial publicity extravaganza—which saw Mamata Banerjee posters come up all over Goa—the party seems to have lost its sheen. At first, the GFP declined its proposal for a merger, preferring that modest bargain with the Congress. Then, at least five new inductees quit the party within weeks. Its 'secular' challenge to the BJP also stands clouded after its alliance with the Maharashtrawadi Gomantak Party (MGP), whose Hindutva inclinations are fairly open. (TMC is contesting 26 seats; MGP, 13—the alliance is not contesting one seat, Panaji). "You might call it an alliance of different ideologies but it will create the ground for a BJP defeat," says Mishra. The TMC think-tank believes it could garner the Catholic votes based upon its secular credentials, while the MGP can make a dent in the BJP's Hindu votes.

Meanwhile, AAP has managed to set off some ripples. Not only was it the first to announce a CM candidate, its choice—the popular Amit Palekar—taps into a fallow part of the field: backward caste politics. AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal had been scouring the landscape for a way to mobilise the Bhandari community, an OBC group. Palekar, a lawyer-activist, is a Bhandari face who fits right into AAP's narrative that it's seeking to claim centrestage for Goa's largest community. As the Brahmin-Maratha-Catholic triangle dominated the region's political history, the Bhandaris have mostly been neglected. It is ironic that it has fallen upon Kejriwal, whose political beginnings lie in anti-reservation politics, to Mandalise Goa, so to speak. "Our talented youth are moving out because there are no opportunities for them," Palekar says, blaming corrupt politicians. "If elected to power, I will

CHECKS AND BALANCES

A look at the strengths, and weaknesses, of the major players

BJP

STRENGTH In power for a decade with a strong organisational network
WEAKNESS Anti-incumbency, rebellion within party
ALLIANCE PARTNER None

CONGRESS

STRENGTH New faces in the fray
WEAKNESS Poor organisation
ALLIANCE PARTNER Goa Forward Party

AAM AADMI PARTY

STRENGTH Contact with the masses in south Goa
WEAKNESS No vision for the state except freebies
ALLIANCE PARTNER None

TRINAMOOL CONGRESS

STRENGTH Impressive campaign
WEAKNESS No mass connect
ALLIANCE PARTNER Maharashtrawadi Gomantak Party